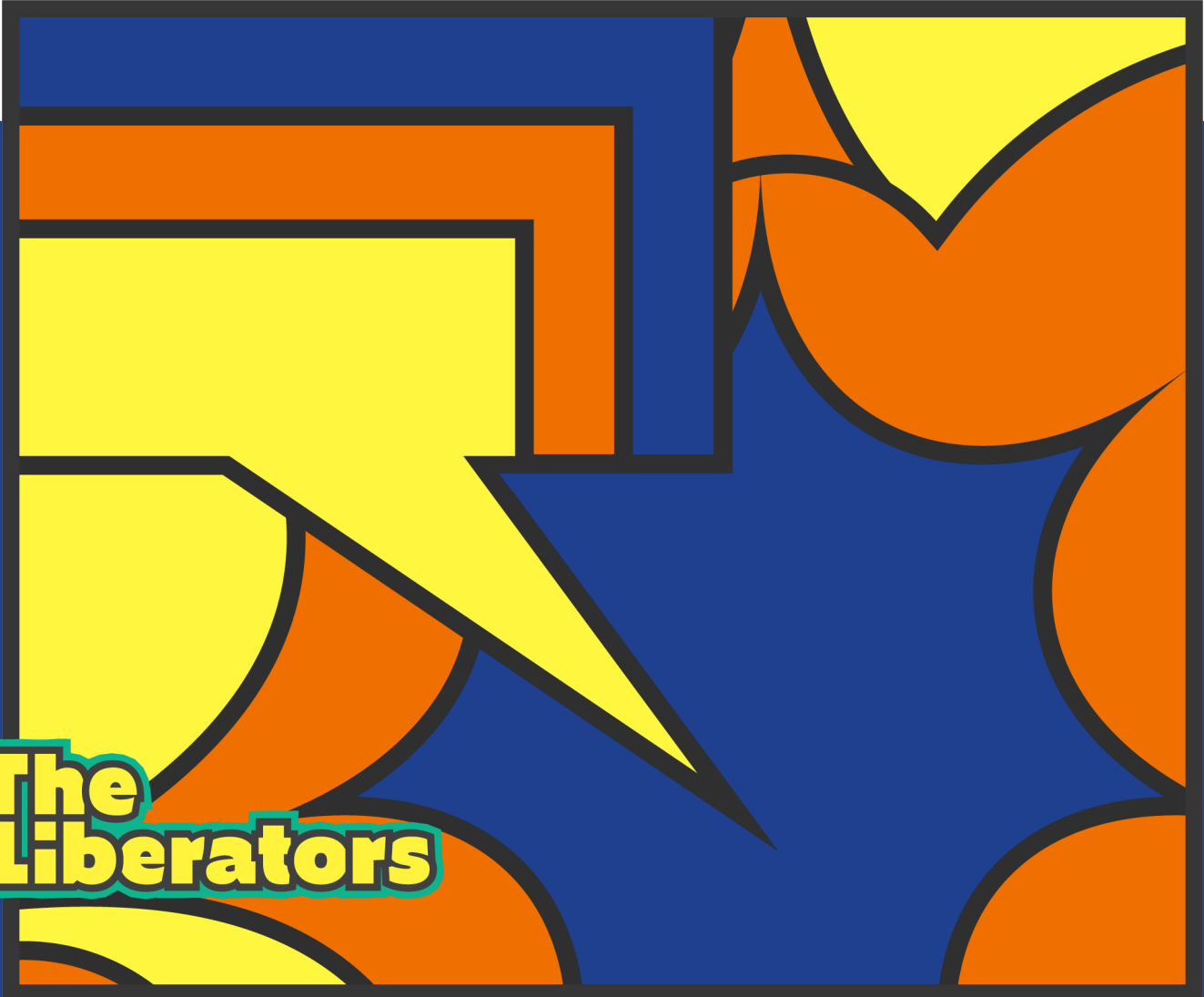


Discover The Needs Of Your Stakeholders With UX Fishbowl

A do-it-yourself workshop to actively listen to the stakeholders of your product and to discover what really matters to them



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

When has your Scrum team talked with the stakeholders about the product they're building? With stakeholders, we don't mean people with an opinion about the product, but someone that really uses (or will use) it frequently. Or someone that invested significantly in the development of the product and will personally benefit from the challenge your product addresses.



In short, a stakeholder is someone who helps you decide what is valuable to work on next because it's important to them the product succeeds.

In our work with Scrum teams, we've noticed that many of them don't frequently interact with their real stakeholders. Sure, they occasionally host a Sprint Review but are the attendee's stakeholders, or just people with an opinion about the product? There are various reasons why they don't frequently interact with stakeholders. It could be that Scrum teams don't know who their real stakeholders are, or they don't know *how* to involve them.

It's important to frequently engage with your stakeholders. You need their experiences, ideas, and feedback to learn what to build next. Maybe, while using an early version of the product, an important new insight emerged that impacts the roadmap and Product Backlog. Or changed circumstances in the market require a quick release of a specific feature. You'll only discover this when you closely collaborate with your stakeholders.

If you recognize this situation and want to improve it, consider giving this do-it-yourself workshop a try. For example, during the Sprint Review. You'll use the Liberating Structure UX Fishbowl to actively listen to your stakeholders and together gain new ideas, insights, and improvements.

Give it try, and let us know the results.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators

Flow

Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Prepare Your Thoughts For The UX Fishbowl

  25 min

Step 3: Gather Feedback From Your Product's Stakeholders

  35 min

Step 4: Share New Ideas And Insights

  25 min

Step 5: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 90 min

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



This workshop uses a basic structure, and shouldn't be difficult to facilitate.

Impact On Survival



With a UX Fishbowl, you'll increase the chances to build a product your stakeholders actually consider valuable. As such, it has a tremendous impact on your survival.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This workshop is feasible from 8 participants and onward, and takes 90 minutes. You can easily scale this workshop up to many Scrum teams, either by running parallel UX Fishbowls or by making the inner circle bigger (although 5 is our recommended limit) and creating more outer circles.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one Scrum team that wants to involve the (potential) stakeholders of their product. Ideally, you have about 3 – 5 stakeholders that can provide you feedback.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.
- If you do this in person, you can already set up an equal number of chairs as you have participants. Create an inner circle of 3–5 chairs, and the rest as outer circles. We always like to keep the circles tight, so that people are seated close together.
- You can either invite participants for the inner circle (the fishbowl) upfront or decide it last-minute. Whatever you do, make sure there is a mix of stakeholders and members of the Scrum team(s) present.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Actual stakeholders? Or just your audience? Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Myth: Only The Product Owner Interacts With Stakeholders. Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Blog post: [Why Zombie Scrum Teams Don't Involve Stakeholders](#)
- Podcast: [The Curious Case of the Missing Stakeholders](#)



Stakeholders? Users? Customers? What's The Difference?



In working with Scrum teams we've learned that not everyone has the same understanding about who the stakeholders of their product are. Or they know who they are, but have no idea where to find them or how to connect with them. Often, teams are also confused about the terminology you find in the Scrum Guide: stakeholders, users, customers... what's the difference? If this is the case for you as well, read the blog post we've included below, or try the do-it-yourself workshop "[Discover Your Stakeholders With A Stakeholder Map](#)".

When is someone a stakeholder, really?

It's such a simple question that you can't help but wonder why we're even asking it. The Scrum framework relies heavily on involving stakeholders. And for good reason. You need them to validate your assumptions and to determine what is valuable (and what isn't).

It's a simple question. Still, many Scrum teams and organizations struggle with it. We've visited Sprint Reviews where all the 'stakeholders' present were internal to the organization; people from marketing and sales, an internal product manager, and an opinionated colleague. None of them were either using or paying for the product and its development. We've found that not including the right stakeholders is one of the primary causes of Zombie Scrum.

Stakeholders, Users, or Customers?

When we talk about Stakeholders, are we talking about Users? Customers? Internal or external customers? Product Managers? While some organizations work exclusively for external customers, many organizations also have people inside the organization that should be included in deciding what is valuable. And in other organizations, the term 'customer' is not something that people are used to, like in NGOs and governmental agencies.

For this reason, the Scrum Guide purposefully talks about 'stakeholders' as a placeholder for anyone who has a stake in the product. Like in a betting game — where the word 'stake' comes from — they personally have something to gain when the team delivers and something to lose when it doesn't.

But particularly in Zombie Scrum, we see many examples where the vagueness of 'stakeholders' is leveraged into making teams believe that only talking to internal stakeholders, domain experts, or intermediaries is exactly what Scrum is all about. For them, it's not necessary to talk to the people using the product or paying for it. And that is a huge issue.

Stakeholders help reduce risk

In product development, we want to balance the user or customer perspective with a business perspective. Only focusing on one of them is going to lead to trouble. Yet in virtually all the Zombie Scrum teams we've worked with, the side of the customers and the users were woefully underrepresented. This leads directly to many of the symptoms of Zombie Scrum. And it keeps risk very high.

"Risk" is the keyword here. When you are developing a product with your team, you are investing time and money into building something that you hope will return on that investment. And stakeholders — in particular users and customers — are your natural allies. By going back to them very frequently, as Scrum encourages, you can verify if you're still on track. Are you still spending their money right? Are you still working towards solving the problem they need your product for?

So, including actual stakeholders is the best way to reduce the risk of building the wrong product and/or solving the wrong problems. But how do you find them?

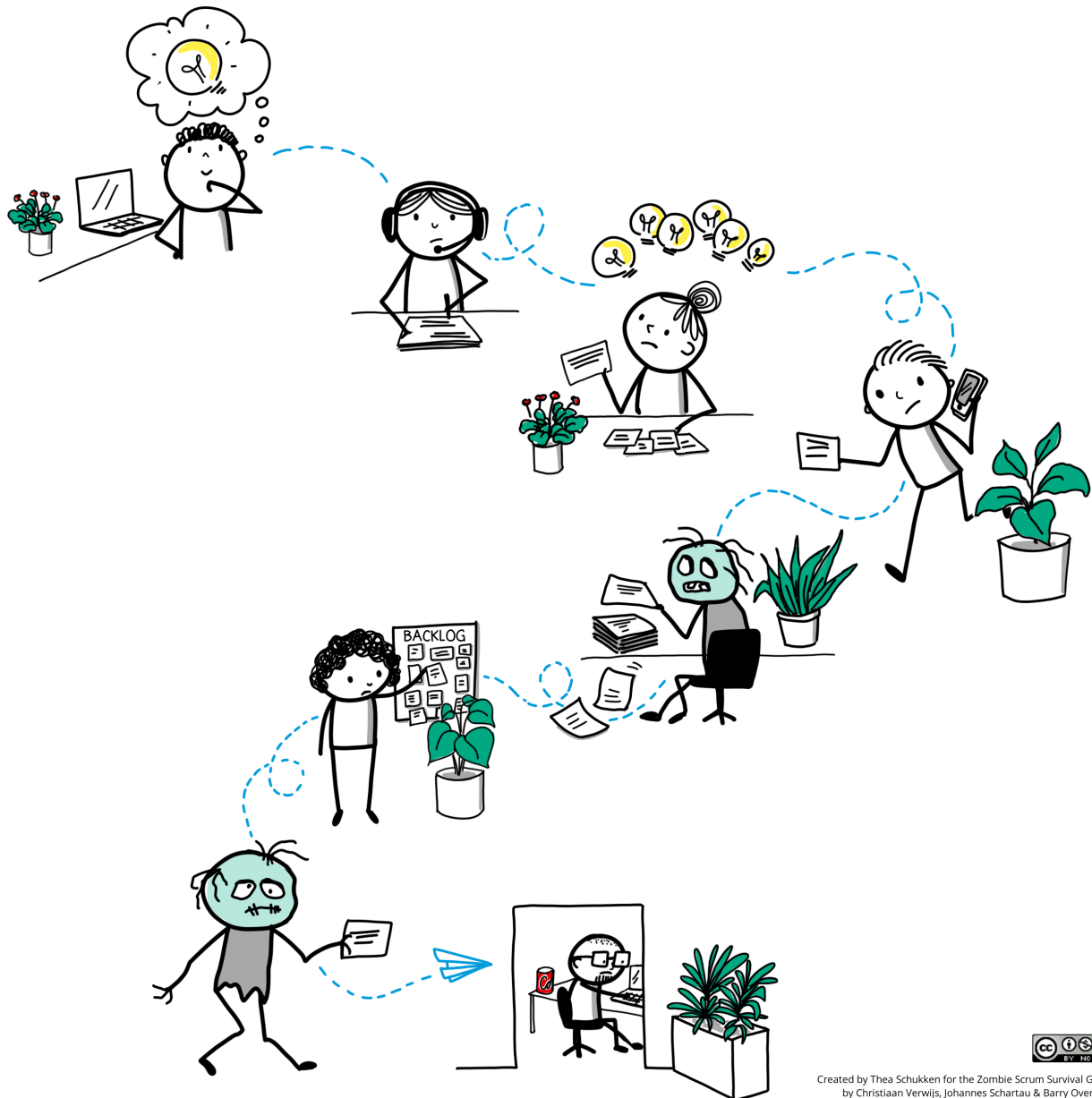
Three questions to find them

So while it is easy to include many people in product development and simply call them 'stakeholders', it is far more difficult to find the people that have an actual stake in your product. We find the following questions helpful to discover if they have a meaningful stake (and either one or more should clearly apply):



- Are they going to use or are they using the product on a regular basis?
- Are they investing significantly in the development of the product?
- Are they personally invested in solving a challenge that your product addresses?

You'll notice that these questions are about value. A stakeholder is someone who helps you decide what is valuable to work on next because it's important to them to get a return on their investment of time and/or money. Everyone else is your 'audience'. This likely includes domain experts, intermediaries, and other people that are interested in your product but have no personal stake in it. You can happily invite them for the ride, but you want to focus your energy and time on your stakeholders. Naturally, this perspective emphasizes the involvement of the people using your product (users) and the people paying for it (customers).



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: Prepare Your Thoughts For The UX Fishbowl

Before we start the User Experience Fishbowl that is at the heart of this workshop, we're first going to help participants prepare their thoughts. If you've invited the stakeholders from the start – something we recommend – then use this exercise to encourage mixing & sharing between all participants. This helps break the ice between everyone. The Liberating Structure [Impromptu Networking](#) helps you do so. It's a great way to quickly let everyone share their thoughts and to notice patterns that seem important for the group.

Invitation

"What hunches do you have about how our stakeholders experience our product. What would make it more useful to them?"

Steps

1. **1 min** First offer the invitation and give everyone a minute to silently get their thinking started.
2. **3 min** Ask everyone to form pairs and let them share their ideas and thoughts with their partner. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms.
3. **6 min** Repeat the previous round twice more. Invite people into new pairs, and let them share their thoughts and observations while noticing patterns.
4. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask the participants for the patterns they noticed. Capture them on a shared surface if you want to.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Rapidly share novel ideas and make personal connections with 'Impromptu Networking'](#)





Step 3: Gather Feedback From Your Product's Stakeholders



Now that you've given the participants time to get their thinking started about their product, we're moving into the stage of the workshop where they are shared. The Liberating Structure [User Experience Fishbowl](#) is a great way to do this in a structured manner, while also allowing for a casual conversation.

Fishbowls consist of an inside circle of people with direct experience with a challenge of interest to those in one or more outer circles. The inside circle shares experience based on a common challenge while the outer circles listen. In alternating rounds, the outer circles generate questions they'd like to ask the inside circle. By focusing strongly on listening and asking questions about experiences, you can use UX Fishbowls to create an environment where people can learn together (rather than get solutions imposed on them).

Invitation

"Talk to each other about the product the Scrum team is developing. Given your experience with the product so far, what stands out for you? What are hopes, worries, or questions you have?"

Steps

1. If you do this in person, create an inner circle of chairs (3 to 5). If you decided on whom to invite for the inner circle beforehand, ask them to take a seat. Otherwise, ask what stakeholders would like to volunteer (this is only relevant if you have a large group of stakeholders in the room. Everyone else positions their seats in close concentric circles around the inner circle. If you do this virtually, the inner circle turns on microphones and webcams and everyone else turns theirs off.
2. **10 min** State the invitation of the UX Fishbowl and invite the inner circle to start an informal conversation about it, as if they're in a car together or at a coffee shop. The outer circles listen and observe with full attention, take notes and remain silent throughout.
3. **4 min** Invite everyone in the outer circles to form small groups (2–3 people) and use their notes to identify big questions or ideas. Collect the questions so that the inner circle can use them as input for the next round. If you do this step virtually, you can form breakouts for the small groups.
4. **10 min** Invite the inner circle to go through the submitted ideas and questions in whatever order works for them. The outer circles listen and take notes, and turn off their webcam and microphone when done virtually. Continue until all submitted ideas and questions have been addressed, or until the timebox expires.

Our Findings

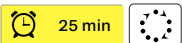
- Try to prevent abstract conversations, encourage the stakeholders to be as specific as possible. If necessary, help tweak the questions in such a way storytelling and the sharing of important experiences are encouraged.
- As a facilitator, gently block interruptions from the outer to the inner circle during rounds 2 and 4. In order to

create space, it is important to protect the structure.

- If you do this more frequently, work hard to mix the people that participate in the inner circle.
- Write the invitation that you'd like the inside circle to discuss on a flip chart (or online whiteboard) so that they can refer to it during the discussion.
- Invite people with experience with a challenge upfront or simply ask who would like to share their (direct) experience.
- Use metaphors to set the tone for the inside circle and create an open atmosphere. Invite the inside circle to imagine they're sharing a car, sitting in a bar, or standing around the water cooler and sharing stories.
- When you do fishbowls with large groups, make sure to add microphones and/or a raised podium or bar stools to keep the inside circle visible to the outside circles;

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- The [article](#) we wrote about User Experience Fishbowl



25 min

Step 4: Share New Ideas And Insights

In the previous step, the stakeholders of your product shared ideas, questions, and maybe some concerns. All other participants – the Scrum teams – suggested topics & questions they wanted the stakeholders to address. In this final step, you'll use the Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) to invite everyone to share their findings of the UX Fishbowl. Make sure to mix stakeholders and team members with each other. If you like, capture insights on a shared workspace.

Invitation

"Now that you've listened to the stakeholders of your product, what new ideas and insights do you have?
What is a good next step for your team?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask everyone to first individually and in silence reflect on the invitation and write down what comes to mind.
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs to share their ideas and build on them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3. **4 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and share their ideas, and how they built on them, again building on their ideas in a group of four. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms.
4. **8 min** Together, collect the key ideas in a shared workspace.

Our Findings

- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will. You can always do a second 1-2-4-ALL if you need to go deeper.
- Facilitate the silent self-reflection firmly, before the paired conversations, and invite everyone to write down their ideas. This allows participants to focus and make ideas tangible and specific.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with [1-2-4-ALL](#)



Step 5: Closing

With this workshop, you've used UX Fishbowl to engage with the stakeholders of your product. Its intention was to learn from their ideas, thoughts, and worries. Ideally, it helped your Scrum team discover (or get confirmed) what is important to focus on in the upcoming period.

Help Us Improve This Workshop

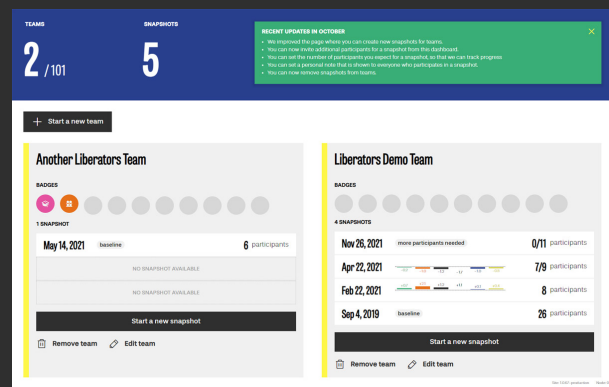
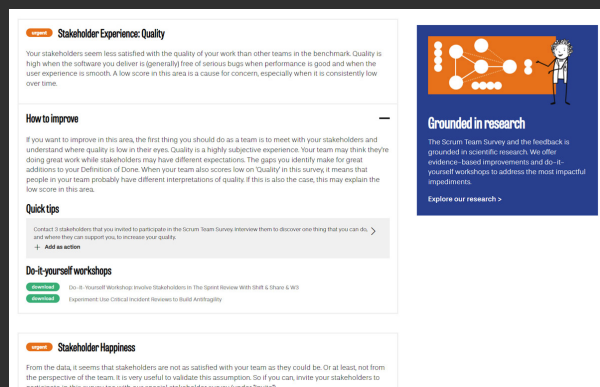
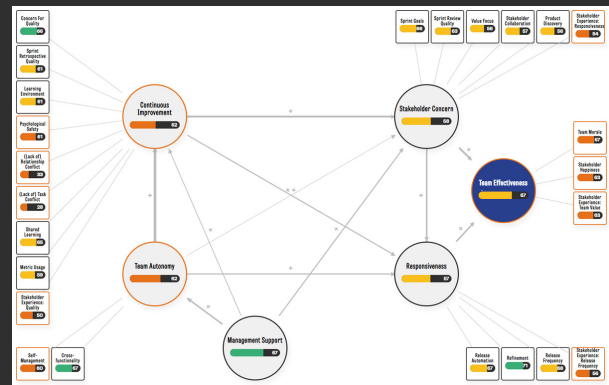
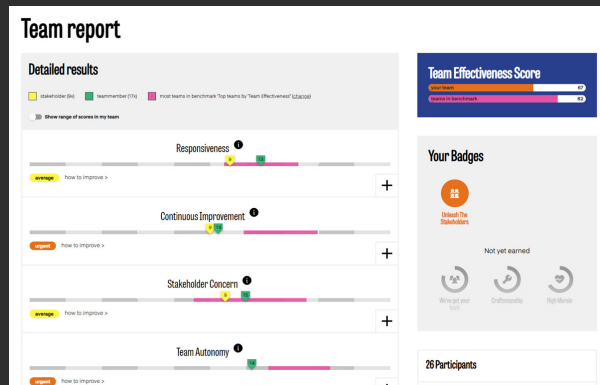
We are eager to learn from your experience with this exercise. You probably discovered much about the flow of the exercise, the use of the invitations, and the impact on the group. What did it make possible for you or your team? What unexpected surprises did you run into? What would make it even better? [Help us learn from your experience by sharing it with us.](#) It only takes a few minutes.



Created by Thaa Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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